

Study Questions: Communication

1. How does Active Inference model communication between two agents? What is "generalized synchrony"?
2. What is the philosophical problem of other minds, and how does Active Inference address it?
3. Explain Friston and Frith's (2015) account of communication as coupled inference. What are the conditions for successful communication?
4. How does Theory of Mind (ToM) function as hierarchical inference in Active Inference?
5. What is Husserl's concept of *Einfühlung* (empathy), and how does it relate to the Active Inference account of modeling other agents?
6. How does Wittgenstein's private language argument relate to the concept of shared generative models?
7. Explain how language functions as a "shared generative model." What does this claim mean precisely?
8. If language shapes the generative model, does language shape perception? Connect this to the Sapir-Whorf hypothesis.
9. How does miscommunication arise in the Active Inference framework? Give a concrete example.
10. What is the role of context in communication from an Active Inference perspective?
11. How does Levinas's ethics of the face relate to the encounter with another inference system?
12. Can non-linguistic communication (gesture, music, dance) be understood through the Active Inference framework? How?
13. How do cultural practices (rituals, institutions) function as long-duration synchronization mechanisms?
14. What is the role of precision in communication? How does "listening carefully" differ from "listening casually" in Active Inference terms?
15. Compare the Active Inference account of communication with Grice's theory of conversational implicature. Are they compatible?
16. How does deception work in the Active Inference framework? The deceiver must model the target's model to predict how the lie will be received.

17. Can AI systems engage in genuine communication under the Active Inference framework, or only in functional imitation?
18. How does the concept of "shared attention" (Tomasello) relate to coupled inference?
19. What challenges does communication between agents with very different generative models (e.g., across cultures, species, or neurodivergent perspectives) pose for the framework?
20. Construct an argument: Does Active Inference show that communication is fundamentally cooperative (Grice, Tomasello), or can it equally account for adversarial communication (propaganda, manipulation)?